

✦ MIDDLE EXPLORER EDITION ✦



Brighton & the Cotswolds

A Family Adventure

Ages 9–12 • 148 pages • Summer 2026
PASSPORT PAGES — THE WORLD IS THEIR STORY.

◆ WELCOME

Hello, *Adventurers!*



You are about to explore a country packed with more history, weirdness, and wonder per **square mile** than almost anywhere on Earth. Britain has Roman walls, medieval castles, secret tunnels, haunted pubs, and a beach made of **millions of pebbles** instead of sand. This book is your guide to all the secret stories hiding in the places you will visit.

England by the Numbers

England is smaller than the state of Louisiana but has over 1,000 years of castle history, 30 million tourists per year, and a river called "Windrush" that sounds like it belongs in a fantasy novel.

Before we go, three golden rules:

They drive on the **LEFT** — look right, then left before crossing!

The UK = England + Scotland + Wales + Northern Ireland

It might rain 4 times in one day. That's normal. Embrace it!



◆ DAY 1-4

Brighton — *London-by-the-Sea*



"The sea is in Brighton's bones. It's been a seaside escape since the days of King George IV, who built a palace that looks like it escaped from a fairy tale."

Here is something that surprises almost everyone: Brighton Beach doesn't have sand. It is covered in millions of smooth, round **pebbles**. When the tide comes in, the waves make a strange, rattling sound as they pull the stones back. Locals call it the **"shingle music"** — and people come from all over the world just to hear it.

Why Pebbles, Not Sand?

Brighton sits on a layer of chalk from the South Downs. Waves smash the chalk into dust that washes away, leaving only flint pebbles. Some of these stones have been rolling in the English Channel since before the Roman Empire.

The Palace Pier

Built in 1899. It's exactly 1,760 feet long — one-third of a mile. During WWII, soldiers **REMOVED** the middle section of the pier to stop enemy boats from landing on it.

The Royal Pavilion — A Palace from Another World

King George IV built this bizarre masterpiece in the early 1800s. It looks like an Indian temple on the outside, but inside it's decorated like a Chinese emperor's palace. Why? Because King George thought it was fun. His dining room table could seat 80 people and had a trapdoor so servants could swap dishes without being seen. Servants literally popped up through the floor!

The Fish & Chip Story

Brighton claims one of the first fish-and-chip shops in England. This combo became a national obsession in the 1860s when railways made it possible to get fresh fish from coast to city fast. During both World Wars, fish and chips were among the **ONLY** foods not rationed. The government knew people needed comfort food to survive wartime. A nation runs on fried fish!



Oxford — *Dreaming Spires*



"Oxford is older than the Aztec Empire. Older than the printing press. When students first walked these halls, the Magna Carta was only 27 years old."

The Bear Inn (Since 1242)

Oxford's oldest pub opened just 27 years after the Magna Carta. Students have been eating here for 780 years — since before Shakespeare was born, before the printing press, before America was discovered. Imagine all the conversations those walls have heard.

Punting — Oxford's Water Sport

You stand on a flat boat and push it along with a long pole. Looks easy. Almost everyone falls in on their first try. The tradition is 200 years old. Magdalen (pronounced MAUD-len) Bridge is where you rent them. Keep an eye out for the giant carp and turtles that live in the river!

The Bodleian Library — 13 Million Secrets

Founded in 1602, this library has over 13 MILLION books stored across 80 miles of underground shelves. Here's the wild part: by law, every single book published in the UK must be given to the Bodleian for free. That means every book in your house — somewhere in those tunnels, there's a copy. The tunnels are so long that librarians use bicycles to get around.

The Covered Market (1774)

This indoor market has been selling food, flowers, and gifts for 250 years. Some butchers still use the same marble slabs their great-grandfathers used. It was originally built to stop street sellers from blocking traffic with their carts. The market has a secret: look up and you will see original Victorian skylights that have been there since day one.

◆ DAYS 5–9

The Cotswolds — *England's Golden Treasure*



The Cotswolds are 800 square miles of rolling hills, honey-colored limestone villages, and stone walls that have stood for centuries. The name comes from "cots" (sheep shelters) and "wolds" (gentle hills). But really, it's the place where **time slowed down**. Most villages still look exactly like they did 300 years ago. There are no neon signs, no fast food chains — just winding lanes, ancient pubs, and the sound of sheep.

Wool = Money. Lots of It.

In the Middle Ages, Cotswold wool was England's most valuable export. A single wool merchant could become as rich as a duke. The phrase "cotton to" (meaning "to get along with") actually comes from old wool-making — "cotted" wool naturally stuck together. The churches you will visit were all built with wool money.

✦ JULY 21 — EVENING

Arrive in Moreton-in-Marsh after driving from Oxford. Your home base for 4 nights.

✦ JULY 22 — DIDDLY SQUAT + BIBURY + STOW

Morning at Clarkson's farm shop. Afternoon at Arlington Row (the passport village!). Evening exploring Stow-on-the-Wold.

✦ JULY 23 — VILLAGE HOPPING

Bourton-on-the-Water, Lower & Upper Slaughter, then Stratford-upon-Avon for Shakespeare's hometown.

✦ JULY 24 — TOWERS + GARDENS

Broadway Tower (and its secret Cold War bunker!), Hidcote Garden, Blenheim Palace.

✦ JULY 25 — CASTLE COMBE

"The prettiest village in England." Then drive to London.

♦ JULY 22

Moreton & *Diddly Squat*



The Tuesday Market — Since 1226!

Every Tuesday for 800 YEARS, the High Street of Moreton-in-Marsh has been filled with over 200 stalls selling local produce, antiques, and crafts. King Henry III granted the town a royal charter in 1226, and they haven't missed a Tuesday since. That's 800 years of people haggling over cheese and vegetables. Your Tuesday market is a piece of living history.



Diddly Squat Farm Shop

Jeremy Clarkson (the car guy from Top Gear) bought this farm in 2008 and discovered he had NO IDEA how to run it. The TV show follows his hilarious disasters. The name? "Diddly Squat" means absolutely nothing — which is what Clarkson knew about farming!



The Farmer's Puppy

Since all July restaurant reservations are full, you'll eat at the food trucks instead. The Farmer's Puppy (open till 3pm) and The Farmer's Dough (pizza till 5pm) serve amazing food right at the farm.

800

YEARS OF TUESDAY MARKETS

200+

STALLS EVERY WEEK

1226

ROYAL CHARTER GRANTED



♦ JULY 22

Bibury — *The Passport Village*

"Arlington Row is the most photographed street in England. It appears on the inside cover of EVERY British passport. If you hold a UK passport, these cottages are in your pocket."

Arlington Row — Built 1380

These honey-colored stone cottages were built 640 years ago as a MONASTIC WOOL STORE. Monks stored their wool here before selling it across Europe. In the 1600s, they were converted into weavers' cottages. Cloth was hung out to dry on "The Rack Isle" opposite — the field is still there. Today, they are a Grade I listed building owned by the National Trust and protected forever.

Movie Star Cottages

Arlington Row has been in Stardust (2007), Bridget Jones's Diary (2001), and countless TV shows. The cottages are so famous that the National Trust had to put up signs asking tourists not to knock on the doors of the people who still live there!

Passport Fame

Since 2000, Arlington Row has appeared on the inside cover of every UK passport. Over 50 million passports have been printed with this image. When you enter the UK, border agents check a page that shows the very place you might visit!

♦ JULY 22-23

Stow & *Bourton*

St Edward's Church — The Doors of Durin?

The north door of this ancient church is framed by two massive yew trees whose gnarled roots arch over the entrance like a doorway from a fantasy novel. Many visitors say it looks exactly like the Doors of Durin from Lord of the Rings. Tolkien was known to have visited the Cotswolds, though nobody knows for sure if this inspired him. The church itself dates to BEFORE 1086 — it's listed in the Domesday Book, which records "30 villagers and a church worth 1000 eels."

Bourton-on-the-Water

Called the "Venice of the Cotswolds" for its five low stone bridges crossing the River Windrush. Kids splash in the river on sunny days. The Model Village is a 1/9th scale replica of the village itself — and the model contains a model of the model!

Dragonfly Maze

A stone-and-hedge maze built in 1995. You follow clues carved into stones to find a hidden golden dragonfly. Fastest time: 4 minutes. Average: 25 minutes of getting lost!

The Battle of Stow (1646)

During the English Civil War, Stow-on-the-Wold was the site of the last major battle. The Royalist army was cornered in the town and defeated. The prisoners were held in St Edward's Church. If you look closely at the church walls, you can still see marks from the fighting.

♦ JULY 23

Stratford-upon-Avon — *Shakespeare's Town*



"William Shakespeare was born here in 1564. He went to school here. He is buried here. And he invented over 1,700 words that you use every single day."

Words Shakespeare Invented

👉 Eyeball, gossip, bedroom, lonely, swagger, addiction, fashionable, generous, gloomy, majestic, and hundreds more. If a word didn't exist, he just MADE IT UP. Try keeping count of how many "Shakespeare words" you hear in a day.

His Classroom Still Exists

👉 Shakespeare's Schoolroom & Guildhall is the exact classroom where he studied Latin and Greek in the 1570s. You can sit at the same desks. The school has been operating for over 600 years. Imagine the graffiti!

Shakespeare by the Numbers

👉 37 plays, 154 sonnets, 1,700+ invented words. Translated into every major language. More performances than any other playwright in history — combined! 🏰

Stratford Butterfly Farm

👉 Hundreds of tropical butterflies fly freely around you. Species from South America, Africa, and Asia. Some butterflies live only 2 weeks. Others (like the Blue Morpho) live 6 months. One of the largest butterfly displays in the UK.

Holy Trinity Church — Shakespeare's grave. He wrote his own epitaph cursing anyone who moves his bones: "Blest be the man that spares these stones, And curst be he that moves my bones."

♦ JULY 24

Broadway Tower & *Hidden Wonders*

"Broadway Tower stands 1,024 feet above the Cotswolds — the second-highest point. On a clear day, you can see 16 counties from the top. That's one-fifth of ALL of England."

A Folly Built for Love

Capability Brown designed this 65-foot tower in 1794. It was built for Lady Coventry, who wanted to know if a beacon fire on the hill could be seen from her house 15 miles away. (Spoiler: yes, it could.) The tower is actually a Saxon-style castle-folly with real rooms, spiral staircases, and a rooftop view that will blow your mind.

The Secret Cold War Bunker

Hidden inside Broadway Hill is a nuclear bunker built during the Cold War. If nuclear war started, a team of observers would crawl in to measure radiation levels. They had 3 weeks of food, a Geiger counter, and a telephone. That's it. The bunker is now a museum — you can squeeze inside and see what it was like to wait out the apocalypse with nothing but canned beans.

Hidcote Manor Garden

One of England's greatest gardens, designed by American horticulturist Lawrence Johnston. It's like a series of outdoor rooms — each one with a different color, smell, and mood. Hedge mazes, rare plants, and secret corners everywhere.

Blenheim Palace?

If you decide to go: this is the only non-royal palace in England. Birthplace of Winston Churchill. It has 187 rooms, 2,000 acres of parkland, and a lake designed by Capability Brown. The palace was a gift from Queen Anne to the Duke of Marlborough for winning a war in 1704.

♦ JULY 25

Castle Combe — *The Prettiest Village*



"Castle Combe is often called 'the prettiest village in England.' It has no traffic lights, no street lamps — just gas lamps and a medieval market cross that has stood for 700 years."

A Village That Looks Like a Movie Set (Because It Is)

Castle Combe has been the backdrop for dozens of films including *Dr. Dolittle* (1967), *The Wolfman*, *Stardust*, and the TV series *Poldark*. The village council charges film crews for the privilege — and uses the money to maintain the ancient buildings. If it looks fake, that's because it's so perfectly preserved it doesn't look real. But it is.

The Market Cross (1350)

Nobody knows exactly who built this stone cross in the village center. It marks where medieval merchants paid tolls to sell their goods. On market days, the cross was surrounded by stalls selling everything from wool to swords.

No Modern Additions

Castle Combe has no new buildings — everything is original. The last new house was built in the 1600s. The village is a protected conservation area, meaning it will look exactly like this for another 400 years.

◆ YOUR MISSION

The Cotswolds *Challenge*

Your mission, should you choose to accept it: Find and complete as many of these challenges as you can during your trip. Check each one off when you do it!



Find the smoothest, flattest pebble on Brighton Beach



Take a photo of Arlington Row — you're holding the passport!



Try Cotswold cheese and rate it 1 to 10



Spot someone falling off a punt in Oxford



Learn one British slang word and use it



Find the hidden golden dragonfly at the Dragonfly Maze



Count the stone bridges at Bourton-on-the-Water



Invent one new word in the style of Shakespeare



Spot a real Cotswold sheep (curly wool counts)



Take a photo from the top of Broadway Tower



Eat fish and chips by the sea in Brighton



Write one journal entry about your favorite moment

◆ Completed: _____ out of 12 ◆

Quick-Fire *Fun Facts*

Brighton Beach

Millions of pebbles. The shingle music is the sound of the waves pulling stones.

Royal Pavilion

Looks Indian outside, Chinese inside. Trapdoor dining table for 80 people.

Palace Pier

1,760 feet. Middle removed in WWII to stop enemy boats.

Bodleian Library

13M books. 80 miles of shelves. Bicycle tunnels.

Arlington Row

1380. Wool store. On every UK passport. In movies.

Didley Squat

Jeremy Clarkson's farm. Name means "nothing." He knew nothing.

St Edward's

Mentioned in 1086 Domesday Book. Doors look like Lord of the Rings.

Shakespeare

1,700+ words invented. Classroom still exists.

Broadway Bunker

Cold War. 3 weeks of food. One Geiger counter. Canned beans.

Remember: The best souvenir is a good story.

You don't need to bring anything home but memories. Every castle you see, every fact you learn, every pebble you skip across Brighton Beach — those are the things that last forever. Have the best adventure.



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